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Felix, Festus and Agrippa

Three rulers who heard Paul: one trembled, one scoffed, one was "almost" persuaded.

In custody at Caesarea, Paul stood before three powerful men. Felix, the governor, heard Paul speak of righteousness, self-control and judgment, and trembled. Yet he put off any decision, hoping for a bribe. His successor, Festus, proposed a trial in Jerusalem to please the Jewish leaders, so Paul appealed to Caesar. King Agrippa II heard Paul's story and answered, "Almost thou persuadest me to be a Christian." All three agreed Paul had done nothing deserving death, yet none is known to have believed.

At a glance

<i>Felix</i>	Roman governor of Judea, c. AD 52–59 (Acts 23:24–24:27)
<i>Drusilla</i>	Felix's wife, "a Jewess" (Acts 24:24)
<i>Festus</i>	Porcius Festus, governor of Judea, c. AD 59–62
<i>Agrippa</i>	Herod Agrippa II; son of the Herod of Acts 12
<i>Bernice</i>	Agrippa's sister, who sat with him at the hearing (Acts 25:13, 23)
<i>Place and time</i>	Caesarea, c. AD 57–59
<i>Main passages</i>	Acts 23:23–26:32

"Then Agrippa said unto Paul, Almost thou persuadest me to be a Christian."

Acts 26:28, KJV

The life of Felix, Festus and Agrippa

Dates are approximate (AD). Felix governed Judea c. AD 52–59 and Festus c. AD 59–62. The exact year Festus arrived is debated.

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| c. AD 52
<i>Judea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Felix takes office
Felix becomes governor of Judea. Paul later tells him he has been "of many years a judge unto this nation." <i>Acts 24:10</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 57
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Paul sent to Felix
After a plot to kill Paul in Jerusalem, the commander Claudius Lysias sends him under heavy guard to Governor Felix at Caesarea. <i>Acts 23:12–35</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 57
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>The hearing
The lawyer Tertullus accuses Paul for the high priest. Paul answers calmly. Felix, who knows about "that way," puts off the case until Lysias comes. <i>Acts 24:1–23</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 57–59
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Felix trembles
With Drusilla, Felix hears Paul speak of "righteousness, temperance, and judgment to come" and trembles. He sends Paul away, but often calls for him, hoping for money. <i>Acts 24:24–26</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 59
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Festus and the appeal
After two years Festus replaces Felix, who leaves Paul bound. When Festus suggests a trial in Jerusalem, Paul appeals to Caesar. <i>Acts 24:27; 25:1–12</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 59
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Before King Agrippa
Agrippa and Bernice visit Festus and hear Paul "with great pomp." Paul tells his story; Festus calls him mad, and Agrippa is almost persuaded. <i>Acts 25:13–26:32</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 59–60
<i>Caesarea</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Sent to Rome
Agrippa says Paul could have gone free if he had not appealed. Paul is sent by sea to Rome under a centurion named Julius. <i>Acts 26:32; 27:1</i></div></div> |

Key activities

Josephus, a first-century Jewish historian, tells much more about these rulers. He says Festus died in office. Before the next governor arrived, the high priest had James, brother of Jesus, put to death in AD 62.

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- I Felix kept Paul under guard.** He ordered Paul "to be kept in Herod's judgment hall" until his accusers came. *Acts 23:35*

 - 2 Felix delayed the verdict.** He put the case off, saying he would decide when Lysias came down. *Acts 24:22-23*

 - 3 Felix trembled but waited.** "Go thy way for this time; when I have a convenient season, I will call for thee." *Acts 24:25*

 - 4 Felix hoped for a bribe.** He sent for Paul often, hoping to be paid to release him. *Acts 24:26*

 - 5 Felix left Paul bound.** "Willing to shew the Jews a pleasure," he left Paul in prison. *Acts 24:27*

 - 6 Festus acted quickly.** Three days after arriving he went up to Jerusalem, heard the charges, then held court in Caesarea. *Acts 25:1-6*

 - 7 Festus granted the appeal.** "Hast thou appealed unto Caesar? unto Caesar shalt thou go." *Acts 25:12*

 - 8 Festus sought Agrippa's help.** He admitted he had "no certain thing to write" to the emperor. *Acts 25:14-27*

 - 9 Festus dismissed the resurrection.** He called Paul mad: "much learning doth make thee mad." *Acts 25:19; 26:24*

 - IO Agrippa gave Paul a hearing.** "Thou art permitted to speak for thyself." *Acts 26:1*

 - II Agrippa stopped short.** He admitted he was almost persuaded, then rose and ended the hearing. *Acts 26:27-31*

 - 12 All agreed Paul was innocent.** "This man doeth nothing worthy of death or of bonds." *Acts 26:31-32*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; these rulers are not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Jeremiah 37:17; 38:14-20	Zedekiah asks for God's word but won't obey
Echo: Daniel 4:27; 5:17-28	Daniel speaks plainly to kings
Echo: Psalm 119:46	"I will speak of thy testimonies also before kings"

New Testament

Acts 23:23-24:27	Paul before Felix
Acts 25:1-12	Paul before Festus; the appeal to Caesar
Acts 25:13-26:32	Paul before Agrippa and Bernice
Acts 12:1-23	Agrippa's father kills James and dies in AD 44
Acts 9:15; Matthew 10:18	Christ's name carried before governors and kings
Echo: John 19:4-16	Pilate found no fault but gave way to pressure

For discussion

- Observe:* What three subjects made Felix tremble (Acts 24:25)?
- Understand:* Felix delayed, Festus scoffed, and Agrippa said "almost." What lay behind each response?
- Apply:* Felix waited for "a convenient season." What step of obedience have you been putting off?
- Apply:* How would you tell, in two minutes, how you came to faith (Acts 26:9-23)?